Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Frost's "The Investment"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of Frost's presentation of the realist who offers "a great deal of dirt with his potato" and the "one who is satisfied with the potato brushed clean" in the sonnet "The Investment" include

alliteration,
assonance,
consonance,
comparison (contrast),
couplet,
envelope (insert) rhyme,
feminine rhyme,
masculine rhyme,
quatrain,
rhetorical question,
sonnet,
theme, and
tone.

The young writer might immediately recognize the speaker's contrasting "staying" with "living" (lines 1-2) and might also make an immediate connection with the intention put forward in the sonnet's concluding couplet, which underscores Frost's declared preference for the "potato brushed clean."

The contestant might choose to approach the poem's thematic concern through an explication, quatrain by quatrain, the first serving as an overture, the second and third stanzas serving to delineate the two perspectives on realism, respectively.

The student might cue in on the title and the two differing investments: the potato harvesting representing an investment colored by the old, perhaps with the "staying," hardly "living"; the investment in new paint and the piano ("some color and music") representing the impulse to live beyond staying.